

St. Paisios' on making excuses for Ourselves

1. On Justifying Ourselves & Blocking Grace

“When we justify ourselves, we shut the door to God’s grace...”

*Spiritual Counsels Vol. 3: Spiritual Struggle

“Justifying ourselves is the greatest obstacle to divine grace.” **

*“The Gurus, the Young Man, and Elder Paisios” by Dionysios Farasiotis (p. 312, in context of humility).

2. On Self-Reproach & Humility

“A person who blames himself is like a bird flying in the air...” **

*Appears in *"Words of Life"* (compiled by the Holy Monastery of St. Paisios, 2015).

“The more you reproach yourself; the more God will justify you...” **

Spiritual Counsels Vol. 4: Family Life (discussions on marital conflicts and humility).

3. On Excuses & Spiritual Stagnation

“The person who makes excuses for his sins cannot be corrected...” **

Spiritual Awakening (Selections from Elder Paisios, 2nd ed., 2013, p. 87).

“Excuses are like chains—they keep us bound to our faults.”**

** Paraphrased from oral teachings; similar idea in *"Arsenios the Great"* (a book he recommended).

4. On Taking Responsibility

“Do not say, ‘It’s his fault,’ but rather, ‘It’s my fault,’ even if it’s only 1% your fault...” **

Spiritual Counsels Vol. 3: Spiritual Struggle (section on brotherly love).

“The devil rejoices when we justify ourselves...” **

"Elder Paisios of Mount Athos: Epistles" (Letter 23, on spiritual warfare).

5. On True Repentance

“Repentance without excuses is the only repentance that heals the soul.” **

"Passions and Virtues"* (compilation from his teachings, Holy Monastery of St. Paisios, p. 56).

“God does not ask for perfection, but for a heart that does not justify evil.” **

Spiritual Counsels Vol. 1: With Pain and Love for Modern Man (general theme).

St. Paisios the Athonite offered **practical and compassionate advice** for those struggling to maintain a consistent daily prayer rule. His guidance emphasized **humility, perseverance, and trust in God’s mercy** rather than rigid legalism.

Here are his key teachings on this subject:

1. Start Small and Be Realistic

“Don’t try to do too much at once. If you take on more than you can handle, you’ll get discouraged and abandon prayer altogether. Begin with a little, but do it with love.” *

“It’s better to say just the ‘Our Father’ with attention than to rush through many prayers while distracted.” *

** *Spiritual Counsels Vol. 1: With Pain and Love for Modern Man*

2. Consistency Over Quantity

“Prayer is like a small flame—if you keep adding wood little by little, it grows. But if you dump too much at once, you’ll smother it.” *

“Even if you can only pray for five minutes, do it every day without fail. God sees your effort.” *

Spiritual Counsels Vol. 3: Spiritual Struggle

3. Don't Be Scrupulous About Failures

“If you miss your prayer rule, don't despair. The devil wants you to either become proud when you keep it or give up when you don't. Just repent and start again.” *

“God doesn't keep a ledger like an accountant; He looks at your heart.”*

**Sayings of Elder Paisios* (oral tradition)*

4. Turn Daily Tasks into Prayer

“When you're working, say the Jesus Prayer quietly. When you're walking, bless the road with a prayer. Turn your whole life into a prayer.” *

“A mother changing diapers can pray more pleasingly than a monk in his cell if her heart is with God.” *

**Spiritual Counsels Vol. 4: Family Life*

5. Struggle Against Distractions

“When your mind wanders, gently bring it back—like training a puppy. Don't get angry at yourself; this is the struggle.” *

“Distractions are like flies—if you ignore them, they'll leave. If you fight them, they'll bother you more.” *

Spiritual Counsels Vol. 3: Spiritual Struggle

6. Let Prayer Flow from Love, Not Obligation

“Prayer should be like a child talking to its father, not like a slave reporting to a master.” *

“If you pray only out of duty, it becomes dry. But if you pray out of love, even a little is enough.” *

**Elder Paisios of Mount Athos: Epistles*

7. Seek Help from the Saints

“Ask the Theotokos and your patron saint to help you pray. They will support you when you're weak.” *

“The saints struggled with prayer too—ask for their intercession, and they’ll teach you.” *

*Oral teachings (recorded in "Words of Life")

St. Paisios advised **gentle persistence** —focusing on quality over quantity, turning failures into humility, and integrating prayer into daily life. His approach was **flexible yet disciplined**, always rooted in **trust in God’s love**.

Would you like more details on a specific aspect (e.g., the Jesus Prayer, dealing with dryness in prayer)?